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Terry Gibbs
Part II

Terry Gibbs' second interview occurred shortly after his 97th birthday and twenty years after his first session. He was interviewed via Zoom on November 5, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe I'm very, very, very pleased to have Terry Gibbs back with me for a second interview twenty plus years after our first one.

TG: Twenty years.

MR: Twenty years. They've been good to you.

TG: You haven't changed a bit, Monk.

MR: Thank you, I'll send that check in the mail for you.

TG: Oh no, you were ugly then, you're ugly now. I love you.

MR: Well you know what we've picked up right where we left off.

TG: You know something wild? The last interview we did all I know is we laughed a lot. I remember that. We laughed a lot. Go ahead.

MR: So I'm going to read — this is the Leonard Feather Encyclopedia of Jazz from 1960. And one Terry Gibbs, even back then, had an entry in it, and at the end it says, "Gibbs has always played with tremendous vitality and a natural beat that established him as the bop era's equivalent of Lionel Hampton."

TG: Well I don't know what he means. I don't know what he means by that. I think maybe popularity or something, because Milt Jackson and I were the only two vibes players on the scene at the time who got well known as vibes players until Teddy Charles and Joe Roland, and another whole bunch of musicians. But we were the first two so there was Lionel Hampton and Red Norvo, so maybe — I'm not sure, but Leonard saw it like that.

MR: I think that he wanted to make a distinction between the styles and the fact that you embraced bebop as a musical language and were able to play it on the vibes. I'm assuming that's his point.

TG: I am a bebop player, you know something, no matter what kind of music they want to call it I am a bebopper. And that's the kind of music I love, that's the kind of music I play, that's the kind of musicians I hired to play with me but I was always playing you know.

MR: In fact, twenty plus years ago you said, about that period in your life when Dizzy and Charlie Parker were coming up with this new thing, you said, "I almost had a nervous breakdown. I stumbled on Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie and it was something so new to me I was looking for in my life, because I had all this technique and I didn't know

TG: That's true. But actually my idols — I never had idols, the people I really admired were Roy Eldridge and Lester Young. And you know how they played, they played beautiful notes, they played pretty, but never a lot of notes. And I had all this technique and I didn't know what to do with the technique. I mean you know, and especially in those days when Milt Jackson used to — the motor would come out where he would slow down the motor or adjusted it to what vibrato you want. Even that I didn't like — I liked it because I liked the slow motor but the point is I couldn't land on a note and maybe feel that emotion of a vibrato, like a trumpet player can go [scats]. So hitting that note and holding it wasn't what I wanted to hear. So I had to get off of it. I had to get off like well you see Dizzy and Bird, they can hold a note because it's a saxophone. And they liked the sound they got out of it. And so they can hold a note with me — I only held a note, there were times where it was the emotion I felt with the vibrato, you know?

MR: Okay.

TG: You know one time Monk, I was working on an invention where you know you have pedals, where you hold, you press down and hold a note to sustain the note. I had double pedals where you can press the other one at the same time and it would adjust the motor — it would go judging to where maybe you want to hear it. You know you would learn, just like a tympani player when the two tympanis came in, because I was an old tympani player. I used to have to do it with the handles. Today they just, with their foot, they press down and they get to the note they want. You know? That's what I wanted with the vibrato. I was going to get to where I could press down and it would get to the vibrato that I wanted to hear and I'd stop. You know there'd be numbers so you'd know exactly, you'd learn what number vibrato, you know there'd be different ones which I, with my brain, have the idea but not the brain how to put it together. I always had ideas but never knew what to do with them.

MR: Okay. Well speaking of ideas, you wrote that when you first tried to play bebop early on that your first note and your last note would be right, and everything in the middle was very questionable.

TG: Well you've got to understand, when I first heard Bird and Diz I was home on furlough. And when I heard — I didn't believe what I was hearing. But I know they were playing double-time, and I was in the Army by the way, I was on furlough. And in the Army I was the drummer with a 38-piece orchestra making all the Army movie pictures. We had a number of drummers in the band so we used to have little jam sessions and I would play vibes, with some of the other drummers playing. And I played straight ahead, you know. But I came back from furlough and went to jam with the guys, hearing Dizzy Gillespie I got the syncopation from Dizzy. Because if you heard Dizzy play and took the notes

be George Gershwin. Because everything he played was a song. Everything that came out of that horn, you slow it down and you could write a lyric to it. So my point, getting back to that first note, I heard all those notes so I wanted to play them but I didn't know what the heck they were doing, so I said the first note I hit was always boom — and I ended up on saying boom. In the middle is [inaudible]. The rhythms were there but not the notes until I came out of the Army and started jamming with players who were learning, like I was, and I would go down to hear Bird and Diz and I was lucky that I learned the bebop language fast. You know I picked up what Dizzy did with the rhythms and the chord changes of the song. Everything was a little different. You know in those days when you played with big bands and you're a jazz player, you had to read music or play the same. Here, with this, you had to have technique, really have technique, you had to be like a classically trained whatever you were playing. Because to play all those notes you had to play your instrument that well. And then you had to know harmony and theory inside out to see how they were going through the chord changes, how they were, even you take one chord like if anybody knows what a C7 is, they could make four chords out of a C7. You could take four different chords and play on the C7 where it would all fit. You wouldn't be out. It would all be in notes you know?

MR: I was watching you recently on a video that went back to I think it was the Regis Philbin days, and it was a very uptempo thing, and you were wailing. And I was trying to imagine what is going through your head when you're playing eighths and sixteenths at an uptempo song and the chords are moving quickly. Can you describe what's happening in your head?

TG: I'll tell you the nearest way I can describe it is I don't know who I'm talking to and I don't know what I'm going to say. That's how it is with playing. I haven't got the slightest idea what you're going to play but that's coming out like I'm talking right now. I'm talking to you on a subject, I'm playing on chord changes and the song. I hear the song in my head. For example, I always tell everybody that, or young kids that want to play for me and show me how good they are or want to study: Don't play the instrument, play the song. Like for example the chord changes to the song "I Got Rhythm" and the blues probably have more songs written on them than any other jazz piece in the world. If George Gershwin were alive and he could sue you for stealing chord changes, I would be in jail just like Dizzy Gillespie would be in jail. I'd have a good roommate, I'd have a good cellmate, but my point is that I've written about 30-40 songs, you know, if anybody knows these songs [scats] or [scats]. They're "I Got Rhythm" chord changes. So when you're playing "Ow" you don't think of "I Got Rhythm" chord changes [scats]. That's what I'm playing on. Not [scats] I'm not playing on "I Got Rhythm" I'm playing on

secrets I found out about writing in the bebop era. They used to take all the great songs and, like "How High the Moon" and "Groovin' High" and take the chord changes and write their own songs in them. Why should we be giving them all the money, you know? You know what's wild, if you want to think back going way back, that Coleman Hawkins' record of "Body and Soul" probably was one of the biggest records ever sold. He didn't get five cents in royalty for writing it, and James Moody, who wrote "Moody's Mood for Love" got sued for a while but he won because they called it "Moody's Mood for Love" and he just used the chord changes. You can't sue anybody for taking chord changes.

MR: I see.

TG: But you can sue them for stealing your melody you know?

MR: Yes, okay. I want to start out, I'm not going to get through your whole life but there was a couple of things near the beginning of the book that really caught my attention, and one was your father's — who hired sidemen — and you said some of them were "schnorrers".

TG: Well, my father taught schnorrers how to be classy musicians. He taught common people, common musicians, you know you're talking about people who escaped from Russia like my father did — they all — and you know any musician my father ever hired it was like the Monday night Birdland jazz jam sessions where when you got there you were hired, you never really knew who you were going to play with — because no music, we all knew the same — we just played all the same songs. My father would have — he was a bandleader, and say he booked two weddings for a Saturday night. He'd have two different bands. My brother would be in charge of one and he'd be at the other, and the musicians that he hired, nobody knew who was going to show up at the job until they saw each other. And they all knew the music, I mean they were the best you could ever hear play what they call Hasidic music. No books, I mean these guys didn't own books, what books? You know I hate to say when I hear young Jewish musicians playing with Jewish music, it's fake. To me it's fake. Because it's almost like kids who go to school today come out and play jazz and they're playing somebody else's chorus or whatever it is. You know, they're not being themselves. These musicians, it was ridiculous I mean how they were — when I was a young kid and playing with them — in fact I was just telling somebody there was a clarinet player called Naftule Brandwein, there's a record he made in 1929 where he's just playing clarinet and they're all about like three minute songs and there's about like twenty songs on this whole [inaudible]. I have the record somewhere, and I was going to send it to my friend, make a copy, because he was amazing. I worked with him, I wrote about him in my book, when I was about 16. He was an alcoholic. And

with my father he couldn't be drunk on the job. But when he was a leader, and I played with him at 16 years old, you see what I wrote about him, I can't say it on our show here, but you'll see I wrote what he said to me.

MR: Yeah. I did see that.

TG: He let me know I was rushing, but boy he just didn't say you're rushing you know.

MR: So a schnorrer was —

TG: It was a common person.

MR: A common person. It reminded me of, I spent a few years —

TG: Half the people you grew up with, yeah.

MR: Yeah, and people who would take things from the plate and take them home. Yeah, yeah.

TG: Yeah. Especially there's a Jewish dish called "kishka." And it really was made the best at these catering halls. They made it so good that you wanted to go round to everybody's plate after the job was over to see if they left it over, you'd put it in your pockets you know. My father taught them that, once again, if you want to be treated with class you've got to act like you have class. And that always remained with me you know.

MR: Okay. I understand that Charlie Parker, in order to borrow money would sometimes promise to show up on your gig. Is that correct?

TG: Yes. Well he did — not me. He did show up on my job, this is when I was just learning bebop of which unfortunately he showed up and scared the hell out of me. If you notice where I write in my book that first of all you'd walk down to Birdland and he'd be standing there and he'd say, "Give me a quarter" or "give me a half dollar." That was a lot of money in those days. And, and these musicians would say, "I don't have it." And he'd say, "Where are you playing tomorrow I'll come and sit in with you." And they gave him the money and people would — word would get out, "Bird's going to come and sit in." He never would show up. He never would know who you were. But I had a great rapport with Bird. The first thing I did was tell him off after he asked me for some money, I said, "You're the greatest musician in the world begging and all that." I really let him know it. And then he said, "Where are you playing tomorrow?" I said, "Over at Georgie Auld's Tin Pan Alley." And I gave him a dollar. You know I mean I knew he never showed up. The place was packed when I got to work. We were the first sixteen bars and out of nowhere I saw him and I'm playing the melody and all of a sudden he walks in with one of his plastic horns around and he came and played the next sixteen bars and he's standing next to me now. Now, once again, as I write in my book if you ask me would I rather follow him playing and then stop playing or fight Mike Tyson? Mike Tyson, one punch I'm out that's the end of it. Here I've got to stand here while he plays 30 choruses and where I come in to play trying not to play anything he just played you

it was only a 32 bar chorus. On the 30th bar, because I knew I wanted to see him go into another chorus, I bent down to tie my shoe. I was on the floor. When he started to play more I got up so then when the 30 bars came closer to 30 bars I went down and tied my shoe. And then once again I had loosened my vibes, I had tied them down — I didn't know what I was doing. But after about 16 choruses on the floor, my piano player who didn't think he was even going to follow him because I would come in next, got panicked how he looked at me on the floor like he's having a nervous breakdown, he says, "I know what you're doing if you think I'm going to follow him you're crazy." We were almost like a bunch of scared little kids. You know Charlie Parker was so far ahead of everybody. You know there's a record of "Cherokee" of him playing years ago at somebody's house with just guitar playing at that fluid tempo. You know sometimes playing fast tempos can be on a song with a lot of chord changes, like for example "Giant Steps" that was done very fast. And you can get away by playing a chromatic scale on that song. Because every two beats is a different chord change. Every two beats. Well Buddy DeFranco and I recorded it at a slower tempo and it was harder to play because then you've got to make sense of all the notes, you know? And Milt Jackson, I think that's the first time he ever said anything nice about me. He reviewed the record and he said, "Now that's the tempo it should have been out and Terry sounded good."

MR: At that point, about that time with the Charlie Parker incident were you in your early twenties?

TG: Oh yeah I had just got out of the Army. It could have been about 1940 — I left the Army in 1940, I was about 24.

MR: Well this is sort of a two part question. I wonder if you had definite goals for a life in music and did your mother support them? Did she think you were going into the right career?

TG: Well it started like I never had goals. I never had goals. And I've been blessed things fell in my lap. I never would have auditioned with Benny Goodman, he called me. I never auditioned with Woody Herman, he called me. I never auditioned with Steve Allen, Regis Philbin, they called me. So I've been blessed in that way, and I never had goals. I wanted to play good. That was my goal if anything, I just wanted to play to where I enjoyed it. I never, you know it's wild to say I never play for an audience. I play for me. I hope they like what I'm doing. By the way there's a call for you, Monk.

MR: Okay yes that's — I'm going to catch a plan out there and get that.

TG: You know it's my doctor but I'm not going to answer it. I want to see what he has to say.

MR: Okay we can cut this out.

[20:25]

TG: Monday at 2:00? Yes I do. All right. Thank you. Bye. I have an appointment. You know it's the only time I ever leave my house is to go to a doctor's office. I sit here most of the time and watch, I'm a big sports nut so I watch a lot of, I bought myself a 75" TV set and I get as close to it as I can so I feel like I'm sitting in the stadium.

MR: So did your mother —

TG: Well let me tell you. I got thrown out of school for hitting a teacher. You read that. Right? I hit a teacher and unbeknownst to me the bandleader and the orchestra leader came to my house to tell my folks that if I came back and apologized to the teacher, the principal and the whole classroom that they were going to give me the scholarship to Juilliard as a snare drummer and tympanist. You know in school, when you get into the percussion section you start out with the triangle because there's a tympanist who's a senior and gradually you graduate to the cymbals and you graduate to maybe another instrument like the snare drum. That's like second highest. And if you're that good you get to be the tympanist. And so they would give me the scholarship to Juilliard. In those days you couldn't get into Juilliard without a scholarship. It wasn't the school that it became later on where it became that — it was a school that a guy like Tony Scott, that's where I first heard him, at Juilliard. But I didn't want to go back to school and my folks, they knew where I was going sort of, musically, and so they didn't force me to go back. My folks were very understanding people in the way, their way of living was completely different than I was. I was an American, they still had that foreign thing in their system. They spoke Russian, Yiddish, and they were learning — my father spoke fairly decent English and I mentioned in my book where my mother learned how to speak English from a black janitor next door, and she sounded, she got to sound too hip for the neighborhood because she would say, "Hey man" or who knows what he was saying, but my mother would talk to me and I said who am I speaking with? One of the guys on 52nd Street. I didn't know what she was saying. But anyhow they were understanding people and they, and of course by that time, after I got out, I didn't want to go back but then I went on the road with bands playing drums. So they saw that and as a result since I was 12 years old, when I was 12 I went on the road with Major Bowes. I was a very talented, I was a child prodigy sort of, really. And so instrumentally I had the xylophones down, really had it down. I could play anything.

MR: Okay. Before we move on from this part of your life, sometimes you read that one of the reasons that bebop became a new style of jazz is that black musicians were trying to weed out the white imitators and that there was a racial component to this music. And I wondered what your observation was back at that time?

TG: I don't believe that in the slightest bit because the feeling among the white and black

along great. There was no problems at all. You know I used to have, I was very fortunate because visually, when you play vibes it's like hearing and seeing a drummer. People don't know if you're good — when they see you do that — wonderful. You know? So I got puppy love, even though I made it pretty good, I got popular at an early age I think. Club owners made me a bandleader. First they would give me a band, then they let me have my own band. And I had a place on 57th Street and 10th Avenue in New York, it was like a big — like a football field room with a little bedroom and so you know everything used to close at 4:00 in the morning in New York, the clubs left at 4:00 in the morning. But I had this place and I used to go buy all these cheap bottles of liquor, bourbon was like 82 cents and I had bottles in my house. And after the job they'd say, "Hey let's go to Gibbs' house" and the place was packed at my house. I'd wake up in the morning and there were people sleeping there on the floor and I didn't even know who they were, it was just whoever showed up it was party time. Because I was blessed. I was a band leader, I was making a decent salary, I had a good place, I was living in Manhattan, and so I was having a lot of fun. There was black and white musicians. Everybody was having a lot of fun.

MR: Was there a recording, one of your early recordings that you did that there was some issue you wrote about with, because it was a —

TG: Duke Jordan.

MR: Duke Jordan.

TG: Yeah. [inaudible] I think it was my first big record date with Allen Eager. Allen Eager — you know who Teddy "Fats" Reig was? Teddy Reig was the first guy to ever record Bird and Diz, for Savoy Records. He ran that company. And Teddy weighed about 400 pounds. And Allen Eager was the hot white tenor player. He was like the first guy that played like Prez, not that well known. But he had be — he played bebop but like Prez. And he played with Bird and Diz and Miles and all those people. Well Allen loved me and Allen had a great, wild sense of humor, so he loved my dumb sense of humor. So he hired me to do this record date. Now I was leaving the next day to join the Tommy Dorsey Band. So I had my vibes at home all packed up and I had a straight vibes set, and I came in and, there's never any music you know. What do you play? He played a riff — I played two riffs and Allen put his name on the songs, and not until thirty years later, because Allen unfortunately in those days was hooked on dope but later on when he got himself straightened out I met him in Florida and he kind of apologized for that. But anyhow, we were recording and Duke, you know, I mentioned the chord change was different. Everything was "I Got Rhythm" kind of chord changes. Duke Jordan wrote "Jordu," which was the middle part or the release or whatever they want to call it, it had

Allen said, "You want to play 'Jordu'?" and I said, "play the melody and I'll learn" you know. It was really fast. He played it and I played it right after him. And so you know we always played short choruses, maybe 16 bars, because records in those days were three minutes. So but I didn't know the release chord changes. So I walked over to Duke, who was out in the boonies mentally at the time, he was stoned out, and I said to him, I whispered in his ear, I said, "Duke, what's the changes in the release?" He said, "Hey why don't you listen?" I said, "I am listening but I can't get it." He says, "Well you've got to listen." And he wouldn't tell me. So I told Allen, "Allen, I don't know the release." He said, "Oh just don't worry about it, just play the melody." So anyhow I was the new hot young kid on the block so as we're playing, and we get to the last chorus, I'm not playing anything at all, Teddy Reig stops the thing and he says, "Hey, why isn't Terry playing?" And he starts walking out into the thing, and he can hardly get through the door he was that big, you know, seriously. And Allen called, "Hey you fat F-, get back in the booth or I'm going home." Because Allen was with me." He says, "Terry doesn't want to play on this song." That was the end of that. And so — but Duke wouldn't tell me the chord changes to the middle part that time. And so I made sure I learned those changes and played the heck out of it.

MR: Okay. Did you enjoy being on the road doing the bus routine, visiting city after city, night after night?

TG: You know what, Monk? That part of your life you never thought about because that was part of getting on the bandstand. That led up to getting dressed, showered, changed, whatever. There were some times when we drove 500 miles and I did all the drive — I was the leader, I was the band boy, I used to load up the instruments because I knew we had to place them in the trunk. We had two cars. I had a Cadillac which in those days you could buy it for four thousand, five thousand dollars. And I had what they call a "sedan delivery." It was like a station wagon without a window. You know? And so then we loaded — I was the band boy, I did all the driving and I had another guy would drive the other car, and sometimes we would drive 500 miles after — we played — Sundays you know we would play the matinee. Those days, believe it or not, we played five or six sets a night. So you'd play at four or five in the afternoon, from three to seven, and then from nine to two or three or four o'clock in the morning you'd play in St. Louis and then like you'd pack up the instruments and get everything ready and go to the hotel check out, boom, everything in the car, drive 500 miles to Toronto, Canada, and maybe get there in time to check in, if not just go right to the job, go change our clothes because we all had, I had uniforms for the band, we all wore dark suits, and get on stage. And once we got on stage Shangri-la came into our lives. We were the happiest idiots you could ever be in

having fun. Me having fun. The audience had fun because we were having fun. You know it's very infectious. But when I got onstage I always — 'cause I love clubs. I hate concerts. I hate big — playing at the Playboy Festival was the most money I ever made for a job, but the audience is twenty feet away, the closest person. There's no rapport with anybody. I get on stage first, and I make sure the band, we have fun. You can talk, you know, you've got something stupid, silly, I'm the best straight man you ever had, but don't fool with the music. Just don't fool with the music. And I would talk if I saw a bald, heavy guy I asked him, "Do you want a toupee?" I don't know what I'd say, who knows what I'd say. I became Don Rickles when I was on stage.

MR: Well I'm going to turn to the book of Gibbs here, because it reminded me of something that I circled. And you wrote, " For most musicians playing music is a crutch. If you have nothing else happening in your life at least you know you can play music. Things are bad for whatever reason, your wife left you, you're not making any money, you can't pay the mortgage, you can always pick up your horn and play. It gives you something that you can't buy."

TG: Because it takes your mind off of everything. It just — you cannot play the jazz if you're not into the music. While I'm playing if I don't hear the next note — you know when you read a newspaper how you read ahead sometimes? It's almost like reading. That's what happens, like with music. You almost hear ahead. And so if I'm thinking about my divorce or alimony or whatever, I can't play. And you're not thinking. That takes away all the pain of everything going on in your life when you play. The moment you finish playing your chorus you may start crying, but while you're playing your chorus you're as happy as a lark you know.

MR: Yeah. You seem to have sensed, over the years, what kind of guidelines or maybe restrictions to put on the people you were leading. In other words you tolerated certain behaviors but not others.

TG: Yeah. You couldn't make any kind of hard dope like that. You could smoke pot. And no smoking at all on stage. I'm talking about the big band, the Dream Band, with the big band. But you can put your cognac underneath the what-do-you-call-it, the stand. I allowed that. Because what I would do is 'cause I always, I never drank off stage. Never drank off stage. But on stage I was the Dean Martin of the vibes. I would have a cognac. I would drink cognac and I would always say, "Ladies and gentlemen, Mel Lewis has a birthday. Let's all wish" —everybody in the band was — by the end of the night he was 125. I was wishing him a Happy Birthday every fourth tune. You know? And so my own thing was for us to have fun. And you know what's wild? Just, of course talking about the Dream Band, the guys felt like it was their band too so they never drank to a point where

Covid, if you don't get your shots you're liable to give it to somebody else. You know. Here, if you couldn't play you'd be hanging up the guy sitting next to you playing his part. You know? If you weren't playing, if it wasn't together it could throw you off.

MR: Wow. And am I correct that when you were — the band was super popular yet the scale was $15 and you were lucky to make $11?

TG: Well after the scale was 19 but I gave the band boy $8 and I made 11. And I was never happier in my whole life. You know what? I read — I didn't start a band, it was a record date that started the band. I think — without having to explain the whole thing — I always tell people that I'm not trying to sell books because the book has been out since 2004, and I don't get much money, if I ever did get much money from the book, I never wrote a book to make money. I wrote it because the publisher asked me and Cary Ginell, whose name I put on there, was a jazz historian. He called me and he said, "I'll work with you on it" he says, you know. But when I say "work on it" I wrote every word in that book. Cary checked out every story, gave me some ideas. I was not going to write about my childhood, Monk. I was going to start out with the Charlie Parker, Benny Goodman, Steve Allen, Frank Sinatra. I was going to start out — he says, "No, you've got to write about your" — and after I wrote it, not realizing, I'll even ask you, as you read my book, I had a crazy aunt I went to the movies with one time that stood up and screamed in the movies. Somewhere in your family you have a crazy uncle or a cousin, don't you?

MR: Of course.

TG: Everybody in the world has one. So, and you could relate to all, and all kids who play in the streets could relate to my stories, you know. So and I was lucky to have a great childhood. I grew up with Tiny Kahn, see Tiny Kahn is when I was from 6 years old until I went in the Army at 19 or 18, until I got with Woody Herman's band really. We were together day and night. And if you can, people who know these names can imagine what we looked like at 15 years old, we looked like Peter Lorre and Sydney Greenstreet walking down the street. Tiny was about 6 foot 2 or something, but he wasn't fat, he was big. And I was small, you know. And nobody wanted to hang out with Tiny. But I knew that he was musically, talent wise, I can't use the word "genius" because he didn't live that long. But if Johnny Mandel was alive or Al Cohn or Manny Albam, these great arrangers, they would tell you they learned arranging from what Tiny was doing. Mel Lewis will tell you he learned drums, the feel, from Tiny Kahn. Jeff Hamilton will tell you that Tiny Kahn, Mel Lewis, how it all started, and by the way you know why they played like that? Because I played that style of drums. Now Monk, you never ever heard me brag about my vibe playing. You never will you know. Half the time that I didn't like what I played after I recorded. But when I was a drummer I was as good as any drummer

Edit

You ever get these crank phone calls saying —

MR: Oh yeah, they are bi-coastal.

TG: They are my biggest fans. I get calls all the time, I mean I can't sign autographs.

MR: Right. So you had mentioned that you rarely had to seek out new things to do, that the phone would ring, like that, except it would be someone with an offer to do something.

TG: Right.

MR: And I admire that and so I wanted to talk about your TV band days. I'm imagining that that was a pressure situation. Like, okay Terry, tomorrow we've got this certain guest and they want this theme, and have it ready. Is that correct?

TG: Well I'll tell you how it all started. I used to be — Steve Allen was my friend. I was friends with Steve in the early 40s, late 40s. He became my friend then he became a big fan of mine, you know. And when he got his TV show he got me as a guest all the time, I was a guest a lot. And we were doing the show in California and I did his show with them and one of the producers, he loved me. He loved my dumb sense of humor, because I'm not a comedian but I've got the wit sort of like Steve's. Steve loved me because, for example, if he did a comedy bit with Jonathan Winters and he wanted to use the band, about four or five of the guys had to get a line or two, he'd give everybody a script with a line. He wouldn't give me a script. He would tell me to improvise — and let me ad lib my line. Because he loved my sense of humor. So anyhow, I was back in New York City, Gerry, my son Gerry was just born. And I get a call, I was living in New York, from California from the producer saying that Steve Allen just had a fight with Westinghouse and quit and they're bringing this young kid in called Regis Philbin who was completely unknown. In fact the first review we ever got said, "What's a Regis Philbin?" Nobody said — because the name was so odd, Regis Philbin. So he said, "I'd like you to come in and see what kind of rapport — and I'd like you to be musical director." I was never a music director, but when I did TV shows I always saw what the producer did. I was interested in how it worked, how they put things out. Would he give Steve two minutes after he talked, on the time thing. So I came in and my audition was to sit with Regis and to talk with him, and see how — because I'd be like a second banana. And I did what I'm doing with you. I'd put him on. I told him he was ugly, I don't know what I — I just was doing Don Rickles. I was just like — I just can't help it, it comes, it just comes out of my mouth like the music comes out of my brain. And so they liked me so they hired me. And the wildest thing, I wouldn't go unless they gave me a 26 week contract. Because that's how usually — the run of the show is usually 26 weeks in those days, instead of 13, 26. And so unfortunately the show got canceled after 20 weeks and so I got paid for six

they said, “Okay we want you, it’s your job, but Steve Allen had a nine piece orchestra, we’ll give you a nine piece orchestra.” I said, “I don’t want it.” They said, “Well what do you mean?” I said, “You mean they give me a big band because we’re opposite Johnny Carson? Or opposite Elliot Lawrence who was with Les Crane — those shows at that time they all had 16 piece bands. And to me a 16 piece band — give me a sextet. I said sextet? Can you make it with a sextet? You see working with Steve Allen, of course I didn’t know who was or what kind of talent he would have, but say he’d get Sarah Vaughan on the show or whatever. What’s the most important thing? A rhythm section. A rhythm section. That’s the whole thing. They traveled with a rhythm section. So I hired the best rhythm section I could find: Colin Bailey was a monster drummer, Monty Budwig who was a monster bass player, Mike Melvoin a monster piano player, and Herb Ellis. And I hired a guy who played all the reeds. And when the scenes would come and if they had a big orchestra arrangement at rehearsal we would just play down the song, you know. And what I would do I would take and arrange — everybody went to lunch and I would take that arrangement and use like their introduction, but not use their introduction, I’d write my own introduction for that song and I’d write my own ending. And in between I’d say okay here the flute will play the high, will play 16 bars, or Herb Ellis will play this. You know. And slowly I learned something years ago, you give them an opening they can understand and give them a closing they understand, that’s all people will remember. Of which I will go into something — a wild story using that theme. I was conducting a lot of telethons in those days. In the old days it wasn’t like a Jerry Lewis Telethon where they rehearse all week and they already had 80 million dollars that the corporations gave them. People were on stage collecting money. And here in California I had my own band. But we got — Steve Allen got called to do a telethon in New York. So I flew in with him, I took Frank Capp on drums, my drummer, and Paul Smith who was doing my TV shows. Paul Smith is the monster of all television piano players. And I called my friend Al Epstein, to give me a band in New York, a real great band with great musicians you know. And so what kind of talent do you get in New York City? You get all the Broadway shows and you never get the star, you always get one of the people in the show, and they never sing the main title of the song. They sing some obscure — which I never heard before, and there’s no rehearsal and they just throw it immediately at you. You kept the music from the Broadway show and you look at it, everything is marked up. You go from G to F and A to B, go back to R, go home and have a glass of water and come back. It’s so ridiculous nobody said — so I found a system. I said, “Here’s what we are going to do. Play the introduction, right? Because that’s written, no problem. Play the introduction, Paul Smith, and I think it was Paul West, the bass player

in at Letter D, the ending." Play the intro — the singer never knew we never played the middle. We'd never do it. So that's what I learned. So I did that for my TV shows, and then, you know it was, it just came naturally to me because the harder part got later on. See all the talent we had for the first maybe two or three weeks, and that's why Regis, in last, where all the talent that already were booked for Steve Allen. And Steve was a big jazz fan so he'd have Sarah Vaughan, Stan Getz, Oscar Peterson, Count Basie. And Regis was never hip to that. You know he didn't know these people — so I remember one time when we — cause I was like second banana, it was like Count Basie and the band, on the show. And they're in the middle of the floor, and Regis interviewing him and Count Basie can yes and no ya to death. You ask him a question, "Yes." "No" and now after about three, four, five yes and nos, Regis is going in the toilet. I said, "Regis, let me ask Basie a question." "Yeah, come on down, Terry." Now I did a two month tour with Basie plus I worked opposite him many times at Birdland. I said, "Hey Basie, tell them the time, the story where Sarah Vaughan" — now whatever it is, now he had to tell the story. So Regis loved me for that, see? Same thing happened with Stan Getz he'd yes and no ya to death. So he had me close with the jazz. But after the two or three weeks of the jazz then people like Eartha Kitt and people that Regis had more in common with came on the show. And Eartha Kitt was wild, I'll tell you, that's a wild story. I'm not sure if I wrote about it. But Eartha used to come into Birdland when I used to work opposite Basie and Sarah Vaughan. And I was only the baby. It was always Count Basie, Sarah Vaughn, Terry Gibbs; Duke Ellington, Dinah Washington, Terry Gibbs. So she knew me as the kid at the club. Now here I'm a musical director. She came in with the music for an 84 piece orchestra with violins and everything. And I told Regis, I'm not going to say — I said, "Eartha, do me a favor. Let me do something, let me do something when everybody goes out to lunch, just sit and talk to Regis, and we'll get a chance to rehearse before the show. We'll get a chance, and I'll tell you what I'm doing. And so what I did, I had Herb Ellis, who was the greatest accompanist in the world, play rubato — no tempo. Because Eartha Kitt could sneak around. In fact I wrote a song called "Earthanova" for when she used to come on the show a lot, it was a bossa nova. And she would walk in and slink in, like you know that sound? And so I had that and then I'd have, if we went in tempo I did one here we played in tempo with the rhythm section. And she could sing. And she loved me for that. She really loved me for that. So now I became not a little kid anymore, I became the musical director of the Regis show. But I would do that with a lot of acts that would come in. I learned how to do that with the dream band I had with Steve Allen with the big band, of course it was big. When I had a little band — everything was jazz with Steve Allen you know.

TG: I'll tell you, I wrote both ways. Sometimes I'd sit down at the piano and I'd fool with different kind of chord changes, I would sing something and I'd write down the first eight bars. Other times I'd be in my car and I always carry paper, and I'd sing something and I thought it was pretty nice, I'd pull over and I'd write for eight bars. I'd take it over and I'd put it in my piano bench. And I'd do that a lot of times. And by the time I record next time I had about sixteen pieces of paper I put in there. I'd take them out and once when I played one I'd say, "What in the hell is this piece of garbage I was thinking about, it's terrible." And then, and that's not bad. So then I would finish the song and write the next eight bars and provide a release. So I did it both ways.

MR: I noticed that in the videos I've seen of you, you rarely have a music stand in front of the vibes.

TG: I memorized everything.

MR: Do you? Wow. And so when you wrote out parts for, let's say your six piece band for Regis —

TG: Then I would have the parts.

MR: Yes.

TG: I'd have to have my part because you know I just wrote it and I didn't even know what I wrote.

MR: Right.

TG: I'll tell you my first show, I've got to tell you this. You know I'm coming from New York and I was still a jazz musician and I'm getting called to do a TV show, I didn't know anything about playing jazz so in my contract it had to be written that I would perform three times a week on camera with my sextet. And so I'd be like an act, you know we'd have an act. And it got to be where I had so much to do that I didn't want to do that. So the first show I took the tune I'd recorded and I had all the music for it that I wrote. So I had my music stand and we rehearsed, I had the music set in front of me. Came show time all of a sudden before the band could play the stage hands all came running over and they're moving things and ripped off my take — took my stand away. I've got no music. What did I write? And luckily I remembered it but I missed one note because the most important thing to me is the ensemble you play at the beginning and at the end. And it's a syndicated show so it's not showing for two weeks later, and for two weeks I was having a nervous breakdown remembering, oh it's going to come on the air that dumb note I played. You know it went by and I didn't even know where that note was, when I saw the TV show. It went by so fast. I swear I'm listening — "where is that note I screwed up?" I didn't even know where it was. And I couldn't play it back. It was on the air.

TG: No, not at all. I mean you know what's so wild? I listen to anybody in the band. For example I wrote all these things where I did a show called "Operation: Entertainment." I had all these things follow me, a singer, a comedian, you know I had all these things I wrote for the band. And while we rehearsed a singer, and then I picked out what number would play them off, and my trumpet player, John Audino said, "Hey Terry, why don't we play eight instead of number four." I said, "Why?" He said, "Because eight's in the same key as the singer is, you know, we'll go right into the same key." I said great. I listened to everybody. If it's a good idea why not use it? You know I mean like I listen to everybody. That's how I learn.

MR: Excellent. When I got to about the middle of the book and I turned the page and I saw the title of the chapter Foggo, I said I know who he's going to talk about now.

TG: You know everybody has a Benny Goodman story but not everybody living — one of my most fun times is I used to do a lot of the jazz cruises, you know, 90 musicians would be on a cruise. And Mel Powell was on one of the cruises. And Mel Powell worked with Benny Goodman way before I did. And we sat there one night talking about Benny Goodman stories, and who else? Maybe Ken Peplowski, he worked for Benny Goodman. Whoever was there that knew Benny Goodman, and it was actually like a bunch of comedians sitting around telling stories. Because Benny Goodman did in real life what a comedian would write in a skit. It would be like you could write a whole skit on one of these incidents. For example I think I wrote this in the book, he used to love it when I told him jokes. I'm standing on 57th Street and sometimes Benny would be staring me in the eye and you think he's listening to you but he's in Pittsburgh. His mind is somewhere else. And I'm telling him this joke and I'm really into it, and I get to the point where it's the punch line and I've got my hands up for the punch line, and he turns around and walks away from me. And I'm standing like this on 57th Street with my hands up in the air. I mean you know before I ever joined Benny Goodman, because I was always a Benny Goodman — I used to love the band, I loved Benny and his playing. I used to hear a story that sounded so farfetched it's like I'll tell you a story about someone with a pair of black shoes, and you tell me it to this person, and you tell it to the next person. By the time you get to the seventh person and it come back to me, it was a red shirt, you know. It sounded so farfetched. But after I worked with him I realized every story I had ever heard about him had to be true. And I was [inaudible] because this man was in left field. He'd forget to button his fly before he went on stage or comb his hair. But he could play the clarinet, forget it. He knew, and he called everybody "Pops." He loved my last name originally, Gubenko, so he called me Gubenko. I'll tell you how, he couldn't remember people's names. One time, I think I wrote about it in the book, he was going to do a tour

of them, the agent, he told Joe Glaser, "Get me" this is in New York, "Get me Ziggy Elman." Ziggy Elman was in California. So I go to the first rehearsal I went with Joe Glaser to Benny's rehearsal, even though I wasn't going to be on the show I just wanted to hear the band. And I'm standing with Joe Glaser and Benny looks at me and he says, "I asked you to get me Ziggy Elman on the trumpet" he says. "That's Ziggy Elman, I flew him in" and Joe Glaser would use every F word in the world, you know I'm telling you, if I told him, he said, "That's not Ziggy Elman." "What do you mean not Ziggy Elman?" Ziggy Elman [Goodman] didn't know the difference between Chris Griffin and Harry James. Everybody was Pops. He didn't know the difference. He didn't know your name. And I used to make jokes, he once called his wife "Pops." At rehearsal, up where he lived, his wife came in, she was in the other room, she said, "Benny, should I bring the guys some Cokes" or something. He says, "Oh not now, Pops." You know? We always said you can imagine what it would be like when he was making love to her, what he called her. "Hey Pops."

MR: Ouch.

TG: Yeah, you know. Well he was foggy. He was in left field. And the reason I entitled a second chapter "El Foggo Rides Again" because of the title of that song, "Benny Rides Again." You know.

MR: Yeah. Okay, so let's suppose you sat on a panel of highly educated music scholars, and you being the jazz representative are asked the question, "What is swing?"

TG: I'd say you're all a bunch of idiots. What kind of question? What is swing? Anything that makes you tap your foot I suppose would be swing music and that's — you know bebop was swing music, make you tap your foot. Any kind of music that makes you tap your foot. That's the only way I can really put that thing into any kind of sense you know. Heck if it makes you drink, it makes you swing it. You know?

MR: Okay. Why is it that sometimes certain bassists and drummers don't necessarily swing as well as two other bassists and drummers?

TG: Well because they're time was different. You see a lot of the time the drummer, you know with a little band a drummer could rush a little bit, really on top. Like let me use Ray Brown for example, playing bass. Ray likes to play on top with that fire, because he's in a little band, you know. In a big band you can't play on top, because you've got sixteen musicians and the drummer, he's the most [inaudible] in the band. The guy, he can't go anywhere but sit on — I call it "sit on it" the tempo, from beginning to the end, they've got to be close to the same tempo because when you've got sixteen guys coming in you're going to play like four bars or something then bring them in, and it better be four bars where they're all counting it together. And so the bass player and drummer, if

The bass player almost has got to play the same kind of time as the drummer. You know? In the big band. In a little band they let, I'd say the tempo could go up a little bit because you all do, everybody, and if there's only four of you you're all going up. With a big band everybody's not going up the same way 'cause you don't think the same way.

MR: Um hum. If I put Terry Gibbs and Jack Sheldon and Chubby Jackson in a room together, I wonder what might occur?

TG: Well first you'd have to call the insane asylum. You call the insane asylum and make a reservation at the insane asylum. Because I don't know it would be a lot of laughs. Talk about — Chubby and I had — a completely differently than Jack and I did. I'll tell you about Jack. You know Jack could get a little risqué on stage. But when he worked with me he knew that he could not do that. I'm selling music and I'll be the straight man, and Jack is funny without having to be dirty. You know he's funny. He's got a great mind. So we had a thing going. We played at the Carnation Hall over at Disneyland. And I hired Jack, because Jack had a good following. And I always featured Jack at the end of the set before I played my ballad, the closing tune, I'd feature Jack. And when I'd announce his name half the audience would come running over to the stage, you know, at Carnation Hall, because they wanted to see Jack because he was funny. And they expected to hear all these — hey but this was Disneyland, you know, Mom and Pop. And he'd say, "Oooh it's so great to be here at Disneyland" and they he would say, "it's nice to be here with Minnie, Mickey and Minnie Mouse" and the moment he'd say Minnie Mouse I'd go right into the music. We made that up because people expected him for many miles to go into one of his routines about some off-the-wall out there with a female, you know. That was Jack Sheldon. Joe Maini was the guy you never had to [inaudible] to. You learned what I wrote about him, about Joe Maini, what he said when it was his birthday with the Dream Band played "Happy Birthday" to him, you heard about the Dream Band. You'd never hand him a mic because he — he was street people.

MR: Yes. So we've been at this for about an hour, I've really enjoyed this. I want to wrap up with a couple of questions. I wonder if you could have done anything else in your life besides being a musician.

TG: You know I did want to be a boxer at one time but it was either that — but I realized playing music was more important to me. I don't think there's anything I actually wanted to do that, you know something Monk? I may have had a lot of mishaps but we all — I'm 97 years old now and we all have had some rainy days. You know. But I am blessed with being, in my 97 years maybe two years of it I would say were dumb, were just something — it's not I regret, it's something I couldn't do anything about. There was a point when I wanted to get custody of my children from somebody who was not fit to have children. I

blessed as I was. If you look at the pictures in the book, all those people, first of all Benny Goodman was the King of Swing. When I was 25 years old and he was 42 I played with Benny. After four bars we were the same age. Music has no numbers. Same age. I mean I wrote about this, not only did I play with Charlie Parker but he worked for me one time for four weeks. But Dizzy Gillespie, who was my friend, who heard me play because I worked opposite him a lot of time, I was sitting by a music store when I was working on Operation: Entertainment, I used to go on the road for nine days and I would be in the office writing music. I was sitting in my — I used to hang out in my music store. Dizzy called me and he said, "Terry, James Moody had a Bell's palsy stroke." This is in California. "Can you come play with me for ten days?" God, he could have called Teddy, he could have called fifty — this was like heaven when he called, you know. Playing with people I idolized as musicians you know. All the best. Bud Powell. And that's one of the reasons I gave up playing also, is I couldn't have a steady band. All the guys who played for me in California, they were great. Tom Ranier, he's on the academy award show. He wrote for "Dancing with the Stars" — these guys were all busy doing what they call studio work. So they'll play with me in town, but I can't travel with them. And playing one night a week, that doesn't do it for me.

MR: Well you answered my next question. I was going to ask you —

TG: I got this crystal ball. I knew that —

MR: Indeed.

TG: And what was the question?

MR: The question was does Terry Gibbs think that there were good old days in his life? And it seems like almost without exception they were all —

TG: All great. Really okay. There was really something every year that was really great and stuck out you know. And let me tell you, let's face it, when you get a chance growing up listening to Benny Goodman and Duke Ellington and get to know these people, get to know these people. You know like I've been on the scene with the Dream Band one time when Duke Ellington introduced the band, and I didn't want to follow it, because that introduction was so great that whatever I played, it would be ridiculous. I mean Duke Ellington was so elegant with his speaking, God, I said I was going to say, "Listen, I'm the greatest, he just said that." You know. So the point is I was blessed to have known these people, know them personally. You know I'll tell you Dizzy Gillespie and I hung out — I did a tour that I did well I'm going to tell you, one show, I probably wrote about that. Yeah the Birdland All-Stars of 1955 or whatever, 7. Billy Eckstine, the headliner with Bobby Tucker played piano, and Sarah Vaughan and Roy Haynes and Jimmy Jones on piano, the Count Basie Band when he had Joe Williams, Frank Foster, Frank Wess,

Southern, Phineas Newborn, Bud Powell. For two months, can you do better than that if you want to play with people? Who's left?

MR: You've already been to heaven, Terry.

TG: I was, I still am. I'm still talking to you. I'm not sure what I'm saying but I'm talking to you.

MR: Well I've really enjoyed this and I want to close with the last thing you wrote in your book, and it said, "Even though we know that into each life a little rain must fall, all in all I've been very fortunate for I've been able to laugh all the way to the bandstand."

TG: Yeah well it's true. It really is true, Monk. I've been fortunate. 'Cause I looked forward to getting on stage. I'm at my most comfortable when I'm on stage. Because I don't work, I have fun. I mean I include my audience, that's why I don't like playing big concerts. If I play for people playing in a ballroom at least the audience is close, they're about two feet away from me so I can tell the guy to get a toupee or whatever, I'm going to tell the guy. Lady get your nose fixed, or whatever it is. I become Don Rickles all of a sudden. But you know what we become friends and they think they're at a party. And it's sort of like my band is always partying anyhow. When we get together it's a party. Because I like to laugh and like I said, I'll play straight for Jack Sheldon, Frank Rossolino, Conte Candoli, Med Flory, these are funny minds. If they want to say something I'll say, "What is it?" and I'll feed them lines. And you know what's wild? A lot of times, Frank Rossolino, I've got to tell you, with the Dream Band. Frank — everybody loved Frank Rossolino and the band. He was one of the funniest people. And I have a habit of going [claps] here it is, and I always give them the tempo. And you do this for about two, three minutes, and the audience they'd be yelling "here it is" and everybody yelled. And I'd say, "One, two," and I'd say, "hey Frank." And I'd ask him any question. "How's your mother," "how's your foot," "how's your car." And he'd get up, Frank would jump up and stomp, and he would start saying the most ridiculous thing, and Frank could yodel by the way, he really could yodel. And he'd wind up yodeling, which had nothing to do with anything. The audience was in stitches. We already won the — we could have played "The Star Spangled Banner" and they would have stood up and cheered. You know.

MR: Well you figured out how to make it all work and I really admire it. And you've made some wonderful —

TG: Well I'm glad you liked the book, I'm glad you liked the book.

MR: Yes indeed. So thank you again, this has been beyond my expectations once again.

TG: Monk, call me twenty years from now and we'll do it again.

MR: All right.

TG: I mean that. I may not be with it but some things good will come out of my brain if I'm talking to you.

MR: No doubt. Thanks a lot.

TG: Thanks for the compliment, Monk.

MR: All right. I'm going to sign off and then we'll say our official good-byes.

TG: All right, thank you, Monk.